

A UNESCO Masterpiece

Ramnagar's Ramlila

The Ramnagar Ramlila is not just a play, but an elaborate, month-long exploration of the epic Ramayana. Below is a more in-depth examination of the specifics that contribute to the exceptional nature of this event.

The Month-Long Show

In contrast to the majority of Ramlilas that typically run for one or two weeks, the performance in Ramnagar stretches out for a complete 31 days. This enables a thorough examination of the complete Ramacharitmanas, Tulsidas' Hindi version of the Ramayana. Every day brings a new part of the story, from Rama's birth and being crowned king to his banishment, Sita's kidnapping, the fierce fight with Ravana, and his victorious homecoming to Ayodhya.

The Sets of Ramlila as Living History

Ramnagar transforms into a lively platform. The riverside of the Ganges changes into different settings from the Ramayana. Fixed sets portray well-known locations such as Ayodhya (featuring a lofty palace), Janakpuri (the birthplace of Sita), Lanka (the demon kingdom of Ravana), Panchavati (the site where Rama stays during exile), and Ashok Vatika (where Sita is imprisoned). The intricate sets, embellished with vivid colors and detailed designs, immerse the audience in the story.

From Script to Soul

The Swarupas, who are actors, go through intense training for several months in preparation for the Ramlila. They are more

than just actors; they transform into the characters they depict. This commitment goes further than just learning lines; some Swarupas also imitate the mannerisms and behaviors of their characters while getting ready. This profound immersion brings unmatched authenticity to their performances.

A sensory banquet

The Ramlila offers more than just a visual display; it provides a sensory-rich encounter. The characters are brought to life with traditional costumes featuring elaborate jewelry and luxurious fabrics. Live music enhances the shows, featuring emotional interpretations of religious songs and intense war chants. The recitation of verses from the Ramacharitmanas by a appointed narrator, called the Vyas, enhances the experience even more.

A Royal Influence

The Varanasi royal family has a crucial part in the Ramlila. The Maharaja actively manages the organization and participates in daily rituals as the main supporter. It is interesting that there is a tradition in which the Maharaja does not watch the final battle scene (Ravana Vadh) out of respect for the death of another king. This royal participation brings an extra touch of magnificence and historical importance to the occasion

A legacy preserved

The Ramnagar Ramlila is not just a form of entertainment; it serves as a vibrant example of India's cultural storytelling heritage. The careful maintenance of ancient practices, the emphasis on verbal narratives, and the dedication to traditional attire and music establish a connection between history and contemporary times. The commitment to protecting cultural heritage is why the Ramlila was recognized by UNESCO.

Witnessing the magic

The Ramnagar Ramlila is more than a performance; it's a cultural immersion unlike any other. Here's a detailed guide to help you plan your visit and experience the magic firsthand.

Planning Your Trip:

- **Dates:** The Ramlila typically takes place over 31 days in September and October. It's best to confirm the exact dates before finalizing your travel plans.
- **Accommodation:** Varanasi offers a wide range of accommodation options, from budget guesthouses to luxurious hotels. Booking well in advance is recommended, especially during the Ramlila period.
- **Essentials:** Comfortable walking shoes, light clothing for the warm weather, a scarf or shawl to cover your head when entering temples (optional but respectful), and a reusable water bottle are recommended.

Experiencing the Ramlila:

- **Locations:** The performances take place across various locations on the banks of the Ganges. Popular venues include the Ramnagar Fort, Lanka Maidan (representing Ravana's kingdom), and other designated performance areas.
- **Timings:** The performances typically begin in the evening, after sunset. Exact timings may vary depending on the day's program.
- **Ambiance:** Be prepared for a vibrant and energetic atmosphere. Large crowds gather to witness the Ramlila, creating a sense of shared devotion and cultural experience.
- **Respecting Traditions:** Dress modestly, and be mindful of local customs. Photography is usually allowed, but avoid using flash during performances.
- **Language:** While Hindi is the primary language used during the Ramlila, some organizers offer programs with translations in

English or other languages. Inquire beforehand if this is important to you.